ordered the 7 Infantry Brigade commander, Brigadier D. K. Palit, to locate the greater part of his brigade in Tawang.

Even though General Thimayya still had a year to go as COAS, Amrik Singh's stance as the GOC of a division was most revealing. Not only was the 'Menon-Kaul duo ruling the roost in Delhi, Mullik had emerged as the third, perhaps even more important centre of power. All said and done, Kaul was still only the QMG while Bogey Sen was the CGS, who should have been responsible for all tactical decisions and their implementation. Sen, however, chose to maintain a passive stance and watched wryly as Kaul virtually usurped his role. With Sen refusing to take responsibility, Mullik stepped into the void and became the de facto CGS/DMO. Unable to grasp the logic behind Thorat's 'defensive line', Mullik in his book, *The Chinese Betrayal*, wrote: 'The main objection by the Army [implying the Thimayya-Thorat combine] was that the ground was not suitable for fighting and it must choose its own ground. This was strange logic. Battles are fought on borders, be they suitable or not.'

After Exercise Lal Qila and the failed attempt by Thorat to win the defence minister over, Thimayya and Thorat seem to have washed their hands off the actual deployment of troops in the Kameng Sector. Under normal circumstances, as the Eastern Army Commander, Thorat should never have let Amrik Singh get away with his sycophantic stance bordering on insubordination. However, with the Eastern Army Commander and the COAS being virtual non-entities, there was little anyone else could do. Says Palit, the man directly affected by Amrik Singh's decision: 'I argued against such a top-heavy deployment both for tactical reasons and because of the absence of logistical facilities, but Amrik would not yield. He countered that Tawang could always be maintained by air and the plans for the forward concentration of my brigade must proceed apace… The truth is we were planning and operating in a doctrinal vacuum. I do not recall receiving any operational guidance except a general warning not to become involved in a skirmish with the Chinese or to approach within three kilometres of the border (except where we had already established posts).'

Having pitchforked troops from the plains of Punjab to Assam into NEFA, the last few months in 1960 proved to be anti-climactic. The border remained quiet; there were no infringements. The alarms that had been raised in Parliament and the high drama around the Dalai Lama's escape had begun to fade from public memory. The general belief, among both the